

Does the use of AI affect our energy bills?

Posted by u/AccomplishedQuote875 • 0 points • 8 comments

Doesn't it take a bunch of electricity to power AI? I noticed people in NYC have been complaining about increasing energy bills is that everyone's experience? Is it because of AI, like ChatGPT. I use it all the time.

Comments

u/Sorry-Programmer9826 • 1 points • 2025-05-09 07:22 UTC

ChatGPT runs in the cloud (read; other people's computers). You personally are not directly paying for the electricity, openAI will be paying that. If you are paying for ChatGPT some of that payment will go towards openAI's energy costs

u/archpaw • 1 points • 2025-05-09 05:12 UTC

Only if you're running it locally. But also, the AI companies want to make a profit, and they wouldn't if they were paying tons of money for electricity for every prompt.

If you are running it locally, you're not going to use any more electricity running your GPU full throttle on AI than you would running it full throttle for gaming. And you're not going to be using the AI continuously for hours on end like you might if you're gaming.

[Here's an article on it that shows how overblown the whole thing is.]
(<https://andymasley.substack.com/p/individual-ai-use-is-not-bad-for>)

u/TechnicalCommittee33 • 2 points • 2025-05-09 04:12 UTC

The energy costs associated with AI are mainly from running the servers and data centres required to train and run the software. This cost is covered by the company that owns the program, not by the consumer. Your individual electricity bills only cover the energy required to run your own computer/phone.

The only way AI would impact your individual electricity bill is if the energy demand made by AI data centres exceeds the current supply. In which case suppliers may increase prices as a way of moderating demand.

u/archpaw • 1 points • 2025-05-09 05:13 UTC

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It's covered by the consumer. Just not in the form of energy bills. The fact that AI is affordable shows that it's not really that big a deal electricity-wise.

u/TechnicalCommittee33 • 1 points • 2025-05-09 06:42 UTC

I mean I wouldn't say it isn't a big deal. Running an AI program isn't that expensive, but a large-scale project like chatGPT would've cost millions to train. The only reason AI is affordable is because of a sufficiently large customer base. There's been plenty of companies that have gone broke before they managed to break even.

u/archpawm • 1 points • 2025-05-09 08:00 UTC

Cost to train is a small part of the cost. Also, it's hard to get a good understanding of exactly what's justifiable from an absolute scale, so functionally it's a lot better just to think about how much a difference it makes per person. And the answer is little to none.

u/TechnicalCommittee33 • 1 points • 2025-05-09 08:59 UTC

Training is often more energy demanding than running the program, and has to be considered if you want to justify the use of AI. When you factor in the energy cost associated with development, AI-generated information often requires more energy than simply getting it from the source. Combine that with the fact that using AI just further increases demand for AI, so you end up with hundreds of models that are virtually indistinguishable from each other, all with their own associated cost to train and run, and no additional benefit to society.

I'm not against AI, but let's not pretend like it doesn't result in a lot of superfluous resource consumption just because it isn't reflected in the individual consumer's energy consumption.

u/Xtoller • 1 points • 2025-05-09 03:24 UTC

Yes, based on a quick search in 2022 it used 2% of global energy, which is as much as a small country. Running AI on servers requires more power. And they expect demand to continue to grow.